

COMMELINALES

This order contains five families, two of which are minor groups of around five species each, plus the three larger families illustrated here. Most are low-growing plants, typically from warmer regions. Many have attractive three-petalled blue flowers (reduced to two petals in some species), making them popular as ornamentals.



10 cm
4 in

TURTLE VINE
Callisia repens
F: Commelinaceae

This succulent plant from forest edges in the American tropics spreads by rooting from creeping stems.



70 cm
2 1/4 ft

TAHITIAN BRIDAL VEIL
Callisia procumbens
F: Commelinaceae
Native to C. and S. America, this species has weak stems and three-petalled, white flowers.

trailing stem

60 cm
23 1/2 in

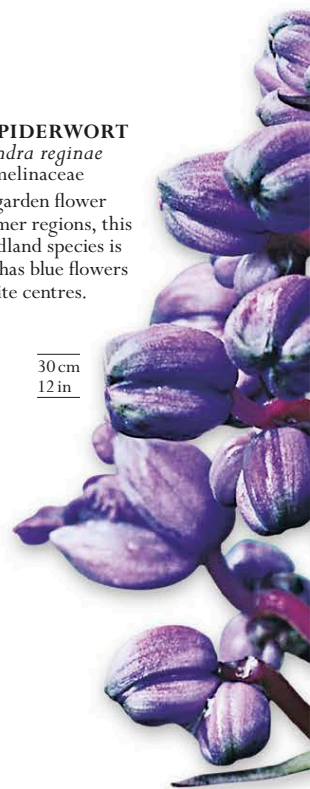


BLUE SPIDERWORT
Commelina coelestis
F: Commelinaceae
Sometimes planted as ground cover, this sprawling plant is native to Mexico and C. America.

QUEEN'S SPIDERWORT
Dichorisandra reginae
F: Commelinaceae

A popular garden flower grown in warmer regions, this tropical woodland species is from Peru. It has blue flowers with white centres.

30 cm
12 in



15 cm
6 in



SILVER INCH PLANT
Tradescantia zebrina
F: Commelinaceae

With striped, succulent foliage, this ground-living species from the tropical Americas is also a popular houseplant.

POALES

The 14 families in the Poales include wind-pollinated families that dominate certain ecosystems: grasses in prairies and savannas, sedges and rushes in bogs and heathlands, especially in the northern hemisphere, and restios in heathlands and swamps in the southern hemisphere. Bromeliads mainly live as epiphytes growing on tropical trees.

PINK QUILL
Wallisia cyanea
F: Bromeliaceae

Native to Ecuador and Peru, pink quill grows on rainforest trees at up to 850 m (2,800 ft) above sea level.

50 cm
20 in



arching stalk of flower cluster

orange-red bracts protect tiny, white flowers

vase-like rosette of leaves collects rainwater

35 cm
14 in



SCARLET STAR
Guzmania lingulata
F: Bromeliaceae

This tree-living bromeliad has a wide native range from C. America to Brazil. It is a popular ornamental species.

45 cm
18 in



30 cm
12 in



red bracts surround flowers

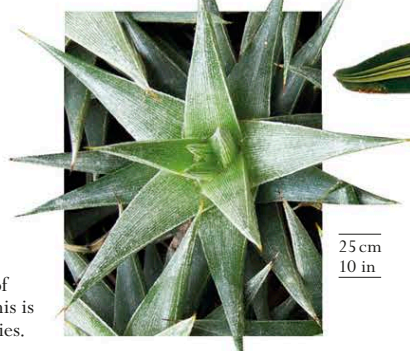
BIRD'S NEST BROMELIAD
Nidularium innocentii
F: Bromeliaceae

The small, white flowers of this Brazilian bromeliad nestle within the chamber formed by the surrounding coloured bracts.

spiny-leaved rosette

LORENTZ'S BROMELIAD
Deuterocohnia lorentziana
F: Bromeliaceae

Native to the Andes of Argentina and Bolivia, this is a ground-dwelling species.



25 cm
10 in

SLENDER CLUB-RUSH
Isolepis cernua
F: Cyperaceae

With narrow green stems and silvery flowerheads, this widespread temperate sedge is also dubbed "fibre-optics grass".

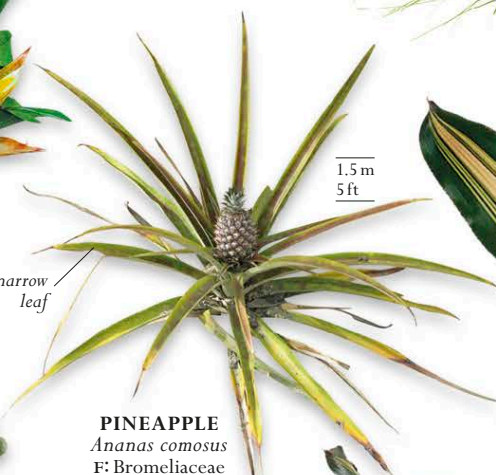


30 cm
12 in

PINEAPPLE
Ananas comosus
F: Bromeliaceae

Christopher Columbus introduced Europeans to this cultivated bromeliad with its large, seedless fruits. Its wild origins are uncertain.

1.5 m
5 ft



30 cm
12 in



BLUSHING BROMELIAD
Neoregelia carolinae
F: Bromeliaceae

At flowering time, the central leaves of this Brazilian bromeliad turn crimson, and it produces blue or violet flowers.